MARYLEBONE ROSTER · LINKS DESIGNER · REFERENCE

# The December 2026 rules



The rules any proposed CEA link for the December 2026 timetable is measured against, with today's link beside each one

Prepared 6 Nov 2026 · the rules and every figure below are read from the same code that writes the proposal sheets, not typed

**HARD LIMITS**
A design must meet these or it cannot be run. Three, and the ceiling of 219 contracted days a year, which is hard too.

**DECEMBER RULES**
The December 2026 staffing rules. Nine of them, each met or not, and scored on every proposal sheet.

**FLEXIBLE RULES**
Three more aimed for when designing. Not scored on the proposal sheets; a presentation may mention them. Page 2.

**FATIGUE FACTORS**
Patterns that tend to tire people. Advisory only: "present" means worth a look, never a breach.

## The basics every rule assumes

**Opening hours.** The station opens at 06:20 (07:15 on a Sunday) and closes at 23:55 (23:25 on a Sunday). **No duty runs past 23:25 on a Sunday** — agreed practice, settled 28 Sep 2026 — although 5 Sunday trains move later, the last at 23:54.

**The link.** 26 lines worked in turn, one week each, Sunday to Saturday; a person on the last line moves to line 1; 5 are cover weeks.

**Cover week.** A line with no fixed shifts: four duties, Monday to Saturday, placed by the roster clerk to cover leave and sickness. Its Sunday can be worked as overtime on top, as any Sunday can (31 Oct 2026).

**Early and late.** A shift starting before 11:00 is an early; from 11:00 it is a late.

**The floor.** Everyone on duty except the four ticket-office staff, who are there for the office's opening hours, not the trains. Monday to Saturday, one of each ticket-office pair helps on the floor at the quiet ends: the morning one until 08:00, the evening one from 19:30. On a Sunday one early is on the floor until 09:00; the two lates are on the floor until 15:00, then both in the office, and one goes back to the floor from 18:00.

**Today's link.** The 20-line link worked now. It is the yardstick, not the target: it meets 4 of the 9 December rules.

## Hard limits MUST BE MET

| LIMIT | WHAT IT MEANS | TODAY'S LINK |
|---|---|---|
| **At least 12 hours between duties** | From the end of one duty to the start of the next, anywhere in the rotation — Saturday into Sunday, and the last line into line 1, included. | ✔ shortest 12h 30m |
| **No more than 13 days worked in a row** | Chiltern's limit, taken at its worst case: a cover week's four duties placed as badly as they can be, and its Sunday worked as overtime. The written source of the 13-day limit is still to be confirmed. | ✔ longest 9 days |
| **The contracted week, exactly** | 35 hours a week on average, Monday to Saturday, across every line of the link; a cover week counts as a contracted week. Sunday duties are paid on top as rest-day working, as they are today. Individual weeks may be longer or shorter; only the average is the contract. | ✔ exactly 35h 00m |
| **No more than 219 contracted days a year** | Today's figure as a ceiling (set 1 Oct 2026): Monday to Saturday, a cover week as four days. At 26 lines it allows 89 Monday-to-Saturday duties at most. | ✔ 219.0 |

## December rules — the 2026 staffing rules MET OR NOT

The staffing headcounts are **minimums**: too few is the problem, never too many. The other rules use the bounds shown. The staffing levels and Sunday cover were confirmed verbally; the 26-line link and 5 cover weeks were set on 1 Oct 2026.

| RULE | WHAT IT ASKS, EXACTLY | TODAY'S LINK |
|---|---|---|
| **At least four on at the open, every day** | Four people on duty from the moment the station opens: 06:20, or 07:15 on a Sunday. | ✘ 4 · 4 · 3 |
| **At least three through to the close, every day** | Three people still on duty until the station closes: 23:55, or 23:25 on a Sunday. | ✘ 2 · 2 · 3 |
| **At least five still on duty at 22:00, every day** | Five people still on duty at 22:00, every day, Sunday included. Only people working *after* 22:00 count; someone finishing at 22:00 does not (both settled 28 Sep 2026). | ✘ 4 · 2 · 3 |
| **Ten on a Sunday** | Ten people working on a Sunday, counted as duties rostered that day. | ✘ 8 |
| **The ticket office: two early and two late, identical shifts, every day** | Two identical early and two identical late shifts for the ticket office: Mon–Fri 06:20–14:20 and 14:00–22:30; Sat 06:20–14:50 and 14:30–22:30; Sun two starting 07:15 and two finishing 22:30. | ✘ Mon–Fri yes · Sat no · Sun no |
| **At least two on the floor at every moment** | At least two people on the station floor at every moment the station is open, checked every five minutes. Ticket-office staff count only while they help on the floor, and only as a whole person: one of each pair at the quiet ends Monday to Saturday; on a Sunday one early until 09:00, both lates until 15:00 and one from 18:00. | ✔ fewest 2 · 2 · 2<br>first at Mon 22:30, Sat 08:00, Sun 07:15 |
| **Handovers: 15 minutes to each closer, 20 in the ticket office (30 on a Sunday)** | Each closer overlaps someone already on duty by 15 minutes; the two ticket-office shifts overlap by 20 (on a Sunday 30, from 15:00). On a Sunday each opener also stays until 15 minutes after the last closer arrives. | ✔ floor met · ticket office 20 min |
| **Sunday duties between 8h and 9h** | Every Sunday duty is between 8 and 9 hours long. | ✔ 8h 00m–8h 55m |
| **No more shift times than today** | No more different shift times in the week than today's link has (18). | ✔ 18 |

Today's figures read Mon–Fri · Saturday · Sunday; a range means the weekdays differ.

THE RULES · CONTINUED

# Flexible rules, fatigue factors and open questions

The rules designs aim for but are not scored on, the advisory list, the preferences, and the questions not yet settled

## Flexible rules AIMED FOR, NOT SCORED

Aimed for when designing, and checked by the searches and solvers. They are **not scored on the proposal sheets**: a proposal that misses one can still be put forward, and a presentation may say which it meets.

| RULE | WHAT IT ASKS, EXACTLY | TODAY'S LINK |
|---|---|---|
| **Fourteen on a Saturday** | Fourteen people working on a Saturday, counted as duties rostered that day. | ✕ 10 |
| **Five cover weeks, as evenly spread as possible** | Five cover weeks in the 26 lines, spread as evenly as 26 allows: the gaps between them differ by one line at most — e.g. lines 1, 6, 11, 16 and 21 (gaps of 5, 5, 5, 5, 6). | ✕ lines 1, 7, 12, 17 |
| **Every weekday closer starts at 15:45 or later** | Every Monday-to-Friday shift that works to the 23:55 close starts at 15:45 or later; 15:30 is too close to today's 15:15. | ✕ closers start at 15:15 |

## Fatigue factors ADVISORY

25 roster patterns that tend to tire people: 21 from the Office of Rail and Road's good-practice guidance, *Fatigue Factors* (page 3, December 2021), and 4 extra checks from the rail industry's fatigue guidance (MRSF). The ORR says they are guidance, not limits. So a factor present is a question to discuss, never a pass or a fail, and a design showing none is not thereby approved.

| CODE | FACTOR | KIND | TODAY'S LINK |
|---|---|---|---|
| **FF2** | Early shift starting 05:00 to 06:59 | Time of day | Every link |
| **FF3** | Very early shift starting before 05:00 | Time of day | Clear |
| **FF5** | Day shift over 12h | Duty length | Clear |
| **FF7** | Early shift over 10h | Duty length | Clear |
| **FF8b** | Fewer than 2 days rest after a block of early starts | Recovery time | Present (2) · up to present (3) |
| **FF11** | More than 13 consecutive shifts without a 48h break | Recovery time | Clear |
| **FF10** | More than 4 consecutive 12h day shifts | Cumulative | Clear |
| **FF15** | More than 4 consecutive early shifts in a rotating pattern | Cumulative | Present (5) · up to present (7) |
| **MRSF** | More than 12 consecutive day shifts | Cumulative | Clear |
| **MRSF** | More than 55 hours worked in any 7-day period | Cumulative | Present (60h 45m) |
| **MRSF** | More than 7 consecutive 8h shifts | Cumulative | Clear · up to present (9) |
| **FF17** | Backward rotating pattern | Circadian | Clear |
| **FF18** | Rotating pattern of about a week | Circadian | Every link |
| **FF19** | Successive start times varying by more than 2 hours definition to confirm | Circadian | Present (6) |
| **FF13** | Less than 12h rest in any 24h | Intervals between duties | Clear |

**Not applicable.** 10 more factors apply to no rotation here: 8 about night shifts (FF1, FF6, FF8, FF9, FF12, FF14, FF16 and FF20), because CEAs do not work nights; FF4, because no shift starts before 05:00 (FF3 counts those); and the MRSF permanent-pattern check, because the link rotates (FF15 is its rotating equivalent). **"Every link"** marks a standing factor — one that comes with the station's hours or with any weekly link, not with a design's choices: FF2 because the station opens at 06:20, and FF18 because a weekly link changes shift type about once a week (the ORR prefers two-day or three-week rotation, *Managing rail staff fatigue* 7.68). **Standing factors are recorded on every sheet for information and are not counted** in any design's fatigue findings, since no weekly design can remove them. The **early** in FF2, FF8b and FF15 is the ORR's — a start from 05:00 to 06:59, since 07:00 is a day shift (*Managing rail staff fatigue*, Appendix E) — not the 11:00 used everywhere else. The last column is today's link, on its fixed duties — the cover weeks left out, as on every sheet; "up to" is the worst place a cover week's four duties could fall, its Sunday worked as overtime.

## Preferences NOT SCORED

Not rules, and not scored. The first two and the last are gains, so a proposal sheet marks a design green where it beats today's link on them; how much each matters is for staff to say.

- **Days in a row.** The Links designer aims for six or fewer, well inside the 13-day limit.
- **Full weekends off.** A Saturday off followed by a Sunday off at the start of the next line. Today's link gives 4 in 20.
- **Weeks on one shift time.** The same clock time Monday to Friday, all earlies or all lates. A week that mixes the two is what people mean by "all over the place".
- **Familiar shift times.** How many of a design's times somebody already works today. A rough guide to what there is to learn, not to what staff will accept.
- **Following the trains.** How closely the floor's staffing follows the December 2026 timetable, hour by hour. A guide, and one way of measuring it among several.

## Still to settle

1. **The source of the 13-day limit.** Somebody confirms where it is written down.
2. **One fatigue definition to confirm.** FF19 is counted on a reading an assessing manager should confirm: FF19 treats a rest day as time to adjust; the ORR (7.71) does not say whether a rest day breaks a run of successive start times — if it does not, every link has it.

**Changing a rule.** Every proposal sheet is checked against this set by the same code. Change a rule and every sheet and this page are re-rendered together, so no sheet is ever judged against an older version of it.